

Art academies

Instigated from the ideas of art historian Giorgio Vasari (1511–74), and established by Cosimo I de' Medici, the first formal art academy began in Florence in 1563. The Accademia de Disegno aimed to arrange and promote exhibitions, organize art education and dictate artistic standards. Membership was considered exceptionally prestigious. A similar association, the Accademia di San Luca, was founded in 1577 in Rome, with the purpose of raising the status of painters, sculptors and architects above mere craftsmen.

The French Académie Royale de Peinture et de Sculpture was founded in Paris in 1648 and later became the Académie des Beaux-Arts. The Parisian Académie aimed to distinguish fine artists from craftsmen – the emphasis on the intellectual side of making art had an appreciable impact on the subjects and styles that became known as Academic art. After this, art academies began opening throughout Europe, imitating the teachings and styles of the French Académie.



Bendz, Life Class at the Copenhagen Academy, 1826